

Improved pitching corps bolsters Miners' chances

By MARK LEIBSON
Times Staff Writer

The UTEP baseball team's weakness last year was certainly no surprise to Coach Larry McFarlin, who made a pitch during his first recruiting campaign to stock his bullpen full of hurlers with pinpoint accuracy.

McFarlin was caught in an unfortunate situation his first year on the job. UTEP waited too late in naming McFarlin as Andy Cohen's replacement and recruiting season had already passed.

With almost all leftovers from the Cohen era, McFarlin's bold preseason prediction that his Miners would win the 1979 Western Athletic Conference championship turned into an embarrassing 20-28 season and another last-place finish in the Southern Division.

UTEP's pitching staff consisted of a several sore arms and a few diehards who carried the Miners through the season.

The end result was no reflection on McFarlin's coaching talent or his ability to turn the UTEP baseball program around.

"We brought in some quality people. It won't go down to picking the best two pitchers and then scraping the barrel," McFarlin said. "We have much more depth than we had last year and it's going to help us."

"Last year's bunch was a good team, but we didn't have depth on the pitching staff. Now that I've had a chance to do my own recruiting, we have more depth. We're going to be young but at least there will be more pitchers to choose from."

Apparently, the pitching staff McFarlin recruited impresses some of UTEP's big hitters.

"I'm glad I don't have to face some of those pitchers," said senior Rick Hayes. "We've got some guys who know how to pitch."

Of the dozen pitchers on the squad, four are southpaws. Freshman Mike King is described by McFarlin as "an excellent control pitcher. He knows how to throw for the spots and his strikeout ratio is high."

Tommy Thompson, a transfer from Hutchinson Junior College in Kansas, has an assortment of pitches. He is not as overpowering as Montie Wren,

who pitched Kermit to the Class AA state high school championship with a stinging fastball and a developing curve ball.

Warren Kastner, recruited heavily by southern schools, is a lanky 6-foot-3 freshman from Louisiana who tries to overpower opponents with his fastball. Two impressive pitchers from Las Vegas are right-handers Mike Maddox and Kelly Simon. Possibly the best pitcher of all is returning senior Tom Carlier.

The 200-pounder had the lowest earned run average (3.81) on the staff last year, allowing 71 hits during 56-plus innings, striking out 23 batters and walking 22.

Senior third baseman Mike Brooks will stabilize UTEP's infield. The Miners lost three starters to graduation. Brooks concluded the '79 season with a .381 batting average, ranked first in runs batted in with 40 and knocked five balls over the fence.

Junior college transfer Rick West will move into a starting position at short, backed up by former Ysleta High switch hitter John Cazares. Sergio Baca, another El Paso product, will see a lot of time at second along with Rudy Armendariz and Rick Altheide.

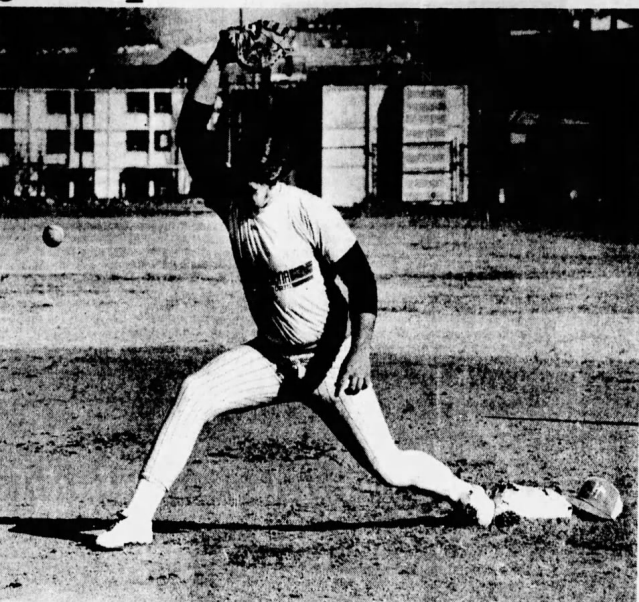
When Thompson is not pitching, McFarlin will have the junior at first base to take advantage of Thompson's hitting ability. "He'll help us quite a bit in the power department," McFarlin assessed. "He'll be dividing time with Rick Hayes who will be our designated hitter against right-handers."

Another power hitter is outfielder James Walker from Mesa J.C. Walker joins returning centerfielder Danny Haygood, who led the Miners in stolen bases with 17, and switch hitting newcomer Greg McCurdy.

Of the four catchers in camp, McFarlin is leaning toward Sal Flores, a WAC Player of the Week in 1977 for an impressive series against Arizona. Flores was injured last year and saved his last year of eligibility by sitting out what would have been his senior year.

"We'll use February to find out who can and can't play," McFarlin said.

McFarlin increased UTEP's schedule from 55 games in '79 to 76 this



SWAT IT BEFORE IT CAUSES ANY MORE DAMAGE
... UTEP first baseman Ricky Hayes reaches for throw in workout

season, including four exhibition games against Ranger Junior College.

The Miners open the season with Lubbock Christian College Feb. 5 and by the end of that week, McFarlin will have a pretty good idea how UTEP stands.

The Miners take on Nevada-Las Vegas in a four-game series in Las

Vegas. The Rebels open their season against defending NCAA champion Cal St.-Fullerton.

UTEP will head back west in March for a six-game road trip to Phoenix and Tucson where the Miners will play a triple-header March 12 beginning at 10 a.m. in Phoenix against Nebraska Wesleyan followed by a 1:30 p.m. start against Grand Canyon

College. Following the game, UTEP will travel to Tucson for an 8 p.m. game against Gonzaga.

Later in the month, UTEP travels to Albuquerque for the Turquoise Tourney which includes Nebraska-Omaha, Iowa and the host New Mexico Lobos.

April 24-27 is circled on UTEP's calendar, when the Miners make their

first baseball trip to Honolulu for a six-game series against Hawaii.

UTEP's non-conference home schedule includes Missouri Valley Conference contenders Creighton (6), Bradley (5) and New Mexico State (2), plus small colleges Moorhead State, New Mexico Highlands and Grand Canyon College.

Conference play begins April 4 at home against Hawaii and concludes May 10 at Dudley Field against San Diego State.

Five days after the regular season concludes, UTEP's baseball field will be the ground floor for a new Business College.

With no immediate plans for a replacement, McFarlin better have had an exceptional recruiting year because it'll be difficult to show a potential recruit the school's playing facility when it is buried under tons of concrete.

UTEP BASEBALL SCHEDULE

Feb. 5	Lubbock Christian (2)	Campus	1 p.m.
Feb. 6	Lubbock Christian (2)	Campus	1 p.m.
Feb. 8	Nevada-Las Vegas	Las Vegas	2:30 p.m.
Feb. 9	Nevada-Las Vegas (2)	Las Vegas	noon
Feb. 10	Nevada-Las Vegas	Las Vegas	10 a.m.
Feb. 15	NM Highlands (2)	Campus	1 p.m.
Feb. 16	NM Highlands (2)	Campus	1 p.m.
Feb. 21	Ranger J.C. (2)	Campus	2 p.m.
Feb. 25	Ranger J.C.	Campus	2 p.m.
Feb. 26	Ranger J.C. (2)	Campus	1 p.m.
Mar. 2	Moorhead State (2)	Dudley	1:30 p.m.
Mar. 3	Moorhead State	Dudley	2 p.m.
Mar. 6	Moorhead State	Dudley	10 p.m.
Mar. 8	Creighton (2)	Dudley	4 p.m.
Mar. 11	Nash Wesleyan	Dudley	1:30 p.m.
Mar. 11	Grand Canyon Col.	Phoenix	10 a.m.
Mar. 12	Nash Wesleyan	Phoenix	1:30 p.m.
Mar. 12	Grand Canyon Col.	Phoenix	1:30 p.m.
Mar. 12	Gonzaga	Tucson	8 p.m.
Mar. 13	Gonzaga	Tucson	noon
Mar. 15	Creighton (2)	Dudley	5 p.m.
Mar. 16	Creighton	Dudley	1 p.m.
Mar. 21	Bradley (2)	Dudley	4 p.m.
Mar. 22	Bradley	Dudley	2:30 p.m.
Mar. 23	Bradley (2)	Dudley	2 p.m.
Mar. 27	Nebraska-Omaha	Albu.	11 a.m.
Mar. 27	Iowa	Albu.	2 p.m.
Mar. 28	New Mexico	Albu.	1 p.m.
Mar. 28	Nebraska-Omaha	Albu.	TBA
Mar. 29	Iowa	Albu.	11 a.m.
Mar. 29	Nebraska-Omaha	Albu.	2 p.m.
Mar. 31	NMSU (2)	Dudley	4 p.m.
Apr. 1	NMSU (2)	Las Cruces	TBA
Apr. 4	Hawaii (2)	Dudley	4 p.m.
Apr. 5	Hawaii (2)	Dudley	4 p.m.
Apr. 11	S. Diego St. (2)	San Diego	TBA
Apr. 12	S. Diego St. (2)	San Diego	TBA
Apr. 17	Grand Canyon Col.	Dudley	2 p.m.
Apr. 18	New Mexico (2)	Dudley	4 p.m.
Apr. 19	New Mexico (2)	Dudley	4 p.m.
Apr. 24	Hawaii	Honolulu	TBA
Apr. 25	Hawaii (2)	Honolulu	TBA
Apr. 27	Hawaii	Honolulu	TBA
Apr. 27	New Mexico (2)	Albu.	TBA
May 3	New Mexico (2)	Albu.	TBA
May 9	S. Diego St. (2)	Dudley	4 p.m.
May 10	S. Diego St. (2)	Dudley	4 p.m.

— Western Athletic Conference game, second game of April '76 doubleheader with Hawaii is non-conference.